

In a nutshell, for a non-tech user, a CM-powered device offers a good experience on good hardware that would be supported for the lifecycle of the phone and will constantly be fresh. That is the promise we bring to the table.

For those who want something extra, customisation is the choice. Those who want even more can unlock the bootloader, get on to the kernel source code and build their own operating system. There are different levels of usage that we provide with CyanogenMod, but there is room for everyone.

Q What has gone into moving Cyanogenmod from 'bedroom Android hack' to a million dollar mobile OS?

The journey has been full of challenges and excitement. In the early days of CM, we used to build it, trade it and ship it with a hacker mindset. But it all just became a bit too much for us to handle. I can quote an example of one of our open source releases called CM7, which is personally my least favourite. I was involved in it from the very beginning. It was too confusing. There was no one central story. We had the idea of user functionality and allowing people to do whatever they wanted to do, but we took it almost too far and it became a confusing experience. As an off-the-shelf product, it wouldn't have worked well for a casual user as it was too tacky.

When Android's Ice Cream Sandwich version came out, we took a step back and went into hibernation for about six months. We thought that we should recreate this product from scratch. We took the lessons learnt from earlier iterations in the previous three years. We did a lot of self-analysis. When you have a community and an open source ecosystem working on any product, it is very easy for members of the community to submit their ideas and patches. During the Android ICS period, we did some introspection and wondered whether this made sense for a lot of people and thought about where exactly we wanted to take our product. We came to the conclusion that we could actually do something better instead of just continuing to create something just for the sake of it. We started focusing on offering a good experience. About two years ago, we had about eight million users. Kirt McMaster, CEO of Cyanogen, proposed that we try taking this experience to about 50 million users. This was something really unheard of, for us. So, Kirt introduced a lot of new structures and relationships, which allowed us to make partnerships with companies like Yu to get a better experience from the hardware perspective as well.

Q What was the idea of joining hands with Yu, backed by Micromax, to enter the Indian market?

Micromax is the No 2 retailer in India. It has a very large presence and understands this market very well. Although it is not a very old company, it has ventured into segments like mobiles, TVs, tablets, etc. We want to partner with

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companies who have a meaningful impact on a grand scale. For Micromax, software was not a prime concern previously. Yureka's Yu, which is an entirely new entity, wants to build a product that lasts for long and gets updated from time to time.

Q How much of the software part is Micromax responsible for?

The software is mostly ours. We work with Qualcomm and Sony for the pieces provided by them, but the software is ours.

Q Cyanogen works on the basis of its community initiatives. So how does one become a member of the CM team?

The community side of CM is based on meritocracy. We welcome all to be a part of the community and then as someone contributes over a period of time, based on the value and quality of the commitment, we give that person access to modify that code directly. This model has worked really well for us over the years, and our total registered user count on our code portal is about 10,000. The model allows us to understand who is around for just ideas versus those who can be good for translations and graphics, and helps us to give them the respective abilities to merge the code directly. That takes a lot of the burden off our shoulders as well because CyanogenMod is an open source project. Our KitKat version runs on 150 different devices across the globe. As we are getting busy with launches like these, it is not possible for us to maintain all the 150 devices internally. So this meritocracy system allows us to give trusted individuals, who have proven themselves over a period of time, the ability to work directly on the product, giving them more of a sense of ownership and allowing us to move a lot faster.

Q So, is this partnership the first of its kind that you have had?

Internationally, this is our third device, as a result of such partnerships. In this partnership that we have with Yu, we have put a lot of emphasis on making an India-specific